

wants to prevent his son from engaging in dangerous behavior, he might force him to stay home while his friends attend a rowdy party.

The competing strategy is most useful when immediate compliance or attention to an issue is necessary (Hocker & Wilmot, 2013). For instance, if one partner does not want to talk about a critical problem (e.g., how to deal with the financial fallout of the wife being laid off from her job), the other partner may engage in competing behaviors to force the partner to confront the issue. In other cases (e.g., finding out one's partner flirted with an ex-lover all night at a party), people may be justified in expressing anger or leveling accusations at their partners. Usually, however, competitive fighting leads to a conflict escalation and harms relationships, especially if positive communication does not counterbalance verbal aggression (Canary & Lakey, 2006).

PUT YOURSELF TO THE TEST

WHAT IS YOUR CONFLICT STYLE?

Think about the last few times you and a relational partner disagreed. How did you behave? Use the

following scale to determine your typical conflict style: 1 = strongly disagree and 7 = strongly agree.

	Strongly Disagree				Strongly Agree		
1. I discuss the problem to try to reach a mutual understanding.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
2. I keep arguing until I prove my point.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
3. I show my partner that I am angry or upset without saying a word.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
4. I sometimes sacrifice my own goals so my partner can meet her or his goals.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
5. I try to find a new solution that will satisfy both our needs.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
6. I usually try to win arguments.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
7. I do not like to talk about issues of disagreement.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
8. I am willing to give up some of my goals in exchange for achieving other goals.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
9. I try to get all my concerns and my partner's concerns out in the open.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7

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	Strongly Disagree				Strongly Agree			
10. I try to get back at my partner by giving the silent treatment or holding a grudge.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
11. I usually try to forget about issues of disagreement so I don't have to confront my partner.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
12. I try to think of a solution that satisfies some of both our needs.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
13. Sometimes I find myself attacking my partner.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
14. I use facial expressions to let my partner know I am angry or upset.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
15. It is important to get both our points of view out in the open.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
16. Sometimes I criticize my partner to show that he or she is wrong.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
17. I try to meet my partner halfway.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
18. If the issue is very important to my partner, I usually give in.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
19. I attempt to work with my partner to find a creative solution we both like.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
20. I tend to show negative feelings through nonverbal communication, such as rolling my eyes.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
21. I usually let my partner take responsibility for bringing up conflict issues.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
22. I would rather not get into a discussion of unpleasant issues.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
23. I give in to my partner to keep my relationship satisfying.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
24. I try to make my partner see things my way.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
25. I avoid bringing up certain issues if my arguments might hurt my partner's feelings.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
26. I might agree with some of my partner's points to make my partner happy.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	

	Strongly Disagree				Strongly Agree			
27. I am likely to give my partner cold or dirty looks as a way of expressing disagreement.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
28. I avoid talking with my partner about disagreements.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
29. I try to find a "middle ground" position that is acceptable to both of us.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
30. I believe that you have to "give a little to get a little" during a disagreement.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	

To obtain your results, add your scores for the following items:

Yielding: Items 4 + 18 + 23 + 25 + 26 = _____

Avoiding: Items 7 + 11 + 21 + 22 + 28 = _____

Collaborating: Items 1 + 5 + 9 + 15 + 19 = _____

Competitive fighting: Items 2 + 6 + 13 + 16 + 24 = _____

Compromising: Items 8 + 12 + 17 + 29 + 30 = _____

Indirect fighting: Items 3 + 10 + 14 + 20 + 27 = _____

Note: Higher scores indicate that you possess more of a particular conflict style.

Compromising

The **compromising** style is direct and moderately cooperative (Blake & Mouton, 1964; Kilmann & Thomas, 1977; Rahim, 1986). Compromise involves searching for a fair, intermediate position that satisfies some of both partner's needs. With compromise, people need to give something up to reach a solution that will meet at least some of their goals. Thus, compromise usually leads to a part-win-part-lose situation. Indeed, people who compromise talk about "splitting the difference" and "meeting the partner halfway."

Compromising behaviors include appealing to fairness, suggesting a trade-off, maximizing wins while minimizing losses, and offering a quick, short-term resolution to the conflict (Hocker & Wilmot, 2013). Mary and Doug could reach this type of resolution by deciding to ground Amanda for 2 weeks instead of a month and deduct money from her allowance for 3 months instead of 6. This way, Mary and Doug both get to administer the punishment they perceive as appropriate, but neither applies the punishment for as long as they originally proposed. In short, they get to keep something but they also have to give up something.

Research suggests that the compromising style is generally perceived to be moderately appropriate and effective (Gross & Guerrero, 2000). This style also tends to be used in happy relationships (Guerrero, 2019). Although this style is not as effective or appropriate

Compromising:
A direct and moderately cooperative conflict style that involves giving up some things you want to get other things you want.